

Harvey Ball

Though it may not be any competition to the Mona Lisa smile, the smiley has made conversations light and sour pouts change to happy million-watt smiles. Meet Harvey Ball, the man behind the famous toothless smile that's so famously used in instant chats and e-mails. Ball sketched it up to pacify employees sulking about a merger. 1962 saw the State Mutual Life Assurance of Worcester, MA, buying up Guarantee Mutual Company of Ohio. Out of the merger sprung low employee morale, which was reason enough for the company to hire Ball to



draw up some graphic support for their campaign to turn the tide of the morale.

Within 10 minutes flat, Ball bowled them over with a smiling, rotund face, which found itself on buttons, desk cards and posters, urging employees to smile. By 1971, 50 million such smiley buttons were sold. The smiley had arrived.

Always the gentleman, Ball never ran after money. He did not apply for a trademark or copyright; neither did he sue Franklin Loufrani, who did just that. And neither did he regret it: "Hey, I can only eat one steak at a time, drive one car at a time."

DigiPick
of the month



The Keyboard That Hanged Itself!

"Installation Art" sent in by Abhisek Sarda and Viju, Dona Paula, Goa. Congratulations!

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UMAX



'How' is where the tech-wizardry comes in—with the power vested by silicon, dustbins will be tagged electronically. The chips would then talk to the collector bins. The reader will differentiate between bottles, cans and plastic. If you have been a good citizen, separating the recyclable from the non-, you would be let off easy, but mixing glass with plastic would raise silicon-hackles with costly consequences. The plan is to charge those who put all their trash in one basket more.

Under the Household Waste Recycling Act 2003, English authorities need to be collecting at least two types of recyclable waste by the end of 2010. The current proposal is meant to help fulfil that goal.

HOAX

Kill Ben

Following the US attack on Iraq, hundreds of hostages from two dozen

countries have been seized. While most were released, some have been killed, beheadings being the most ghastly method of execution.

Within the volatile emotional atmosphere thus created, was released, recently, a video clip showing a beheading. This particular video turned out to be a hoax perpetrated by a US citizen.

A San Francisco computer expert was responsible for pulling the wool over millions of eyes that watch the Internet for such news. Benjamin

Vanderford, 22, posted the film on a Web site used by militants in a format that was used by Al Qaeda ally Abu Musab al-Zarqawi. The video showed an American (Vanderford) being beheaded as a warning to the US to leave Iraq. The fake video was shot in a garage with a friend's help.

The video was shot in a friend's garage using dye as blood, a tape reading of the Quran, and mutilated bodies and sound effects from various Web sources. It was posted onto various P2P services such as KaZaA.

Vanderford intended to

